



UNVEILED CM Stalin with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi; (right) AIADMK boss E. Palaniswami, centre, with the party manifesto

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and party aspirants alike, has not gone unnoticed...it has injected fresh energy to an already upbeat campaign."

The DMK has raised issues such as the 'threat' the BJP poses to India's federal polity and democracy, to Dravidian identity and cultural rights including the language question, and the tenuous Centre-state relations, especially financial concerns. The counter-narrative of the AIADMK and the BJP is about the DMK being a family party, much like many of its partners in the Opposition I.N.D.I.A. alliance.

The ruling party completes three years in office in May, so anti-incumbency will be a factor. Manivannan points to the faultlines and says, "Corruption allegations stick to the DMK like iron dust on a magnet, especially with the tainted and tired leaders surrounding Stalin. The family-first approach has also spread to the districts with the next generation emerging from the homes of influential leaders."

Meanwhile, the AIADMK, despite the absence of an iconic leader, remains an influential force because of its cadre strength and the voters' identification with the 'two leaves' party symbol. EPS, now well-known and accepted as a leader in his own right, may lack Jayalalithaa's charisma, but there is no denying he has steered the party out of some rough waters. "EPS may not measure up to party founder M.G. Ramachandran or Jayalalithaa," says

DMK CHIEF M.K. STALIN IS LEAVING LITTLE TO CHANCE IN WHAT HE CALLS THE "FINAL FIGHT AGAINST FASCISM"

Moorthy, "but he had the gumption to pull out of the NDA, thereby ensuring that the AIADMK is a bigger draw this year. Many of those who drifted to the DMK have returned to the party."

The BJP's presence has made it a three-cornered contest in many constituencies, while in some, like Kanyakumari and the Nilgiris, it is perceived as a straight fight between the saffron party and the DMK. Whether the party wins seats or not, the goal is to push the AIADMK to third place wherever it can. Such an outcome could help the saffron party project itself as a credible alternative in Dravidian Tamil Nadu ahead of the 2026 state election.

The BJP's principal ally in the state is now the PMK, but analysts believe that the alliance will not help it win seats. "Neither party has strongholds to share, but with the PMK's fixed five per cent vote share, the BJP is trying to achieve a tactical advantage of denying the AIADMK," says Moorthy. PM Modi has skilfully avoided targeting the ex-ally, for the BJP is hoping to woo a significant number of the AIADMK rank and file by the time the 2026 assembly election comes up. By getting the PMK onboard, it also expects to erase the perception of being a pro-Brahmin party in the state.

Besides the PMK, the BJP has enlisted smaller parties to contest on its lotus symbol which, on paper, will show the party vote share to be higher than it is. By fielding prominent faces like Union minister of state L. Murugan in the Nilgiris and ex-Telangana governor Tamilisai Soundararajan in South Chennai, the party is hoping to boost vote share and visibility. Its campaign against corruption and nepotism in the DMK, though, is losing steam, especially after it chose the PMK and Tamil Manila Congress as allies.

The chinks notwithstanding, analysts maintain that the DMK remains the party to beat in Tamil Nadu. "As of now, the DMK enjoys a clear edge," says Manivannan. "The party/government's ideological resistance to the BJP has reinvigorated the spirit of social justice and the Dravidian movement in the state." Still, it will take all of Stalin's skills to win big as the DMK and allies did in 2019. ■